2.5 Tabgha

(Heptapegon; Ein-Sheva)

Summary of the description of the Property and its history and development

New Testament reference

- Feeding the five thousand with the five loaves and the two fish (Matthew 14:13-21, Mark 6:30-44, Luke 9:10-17, John 6: 1-15)
- Feeding 4000 with the seven loaves and some fish (Matt. 15: 32-39; Mark 8: 1-10)
- Jesus' third appearance after resurrection and the conferring of the primacy on St. Peter (John 21:1-19)
- The Sermon **on the Mount (Matthew Chapters 5-7, Luke 6:17-49)**

Description of Property

The Benedictine compound and Church of the Multiplication of Loaves and Fishes: 4th century C.E. chapel and 5th-6th centuries Byzantine monumental church adorned with mosaic floors including a depiction of a basket with fish and loaves commemorating the miracle of the multiplication and a modern monastery

The Italian-Franciscan compound: Byzantine and Medieval remains of the Church of the Primacy of St. Peter ('Mensa Christi'); quarried 'steps' where Jesus stood when reappearing before the apostles after his resurrection; Crusader structure, aqueducts and water-run flour mills; Ancient harbor

The ANSMI (**Associazione Nazionale Italiana Ernesto Schiapparelli**) compound: The main spring of Heptapegon: Ein Tabgha (Ein Nur)

The northern slope: 4th century Beatitude chapel and 'Hillcrest of Eremos'

The Tabgha Valley: lush valley, fruit trees, ancient stone anchors on shoreline

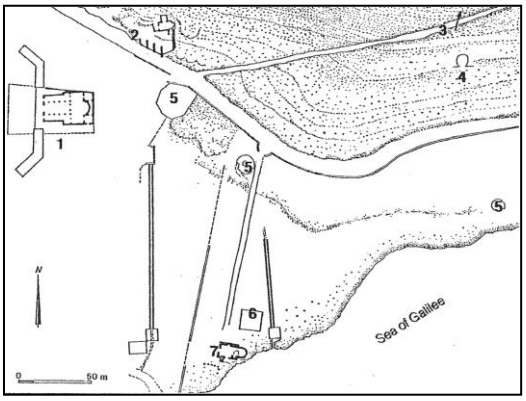
History and Development

- Ancient fishing ground and irrigated valley
- since the 4th century C.E. also a sacred pilgrimage site
- Late 19th century: Land purchased by Italian and German Catholic associations
- 1911-1980: excavations uncovering three ancient Church-sites and their environs
- 1980: erection of new Church of the Multiplication incorporating the ancient Byzantine remains
- 1964, 2000: visits of Pope Paul VI and Pope John Paul II

Detailed description of the Property and its history and development

Name and Identification

The *Heptapegon* – Greek for '(Land of the) Seven Springs' - is mentioned in Byzantine and medieval sources referring to a small water-rich valley on the north-western shore of the Sea of Galilee (Fig. 74); Arabic *Tabgha* is today the popular version used in referring to the



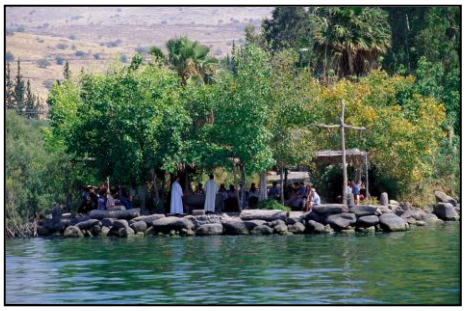
valley and its sites, while *Ein-Sheva* is its rendering and official name in modern Hebrew. Josephus Flavius (Wars 3.10.8), when describing in the late 1st century C.E. the great fertility of the district of Gennesar along the western shores of the Sea of Galilee, refers to the gushing springs of this valley as '(the fountain of) Caphernaum' which watered the surrounding area, and which was believed by some to be an 'offshoot of the Nile' as it breeds fish like those caught in the lake of Alexandria (see below for a remarkable portrayal of scenes from the Egyptian Nile depicted on the 6th century mosaic floor of the Church of the Multiplication). Since the 4th century C.E. at least, the environs of *Tabgha* have been identified with the location of three important events in the ministry of Jesus: the miracle of the multiplication of the loaves and fish and feeding of the multitude (Matthew 14:13-21; Mark 6:31-46), the Sermon on the Mount (Matthew 5-7; Luke 6: 17-49) and the appearance of the resurrected Christ and conferring of the primacy on St. Peter (John 21). This is witnessed by literary sources (Egeria's travels to the Holy Land), and the erection of the first Church of the Multiplication, the first Church of the Primacy of St. Peter and the Chapel commemorating the Sermon on the Mount (Fig. 64).

Description of Heptapegon (Tabgha) at the present time

Fig. 65. Heptapgon (Tabgha): aerial view (from the south) of the site and its surroundings

The Christian Benedictine compound and Church of the Multiplication: This area (Fig. 65), including the Church of the Multiplication of the Loaves and Fishes and its environs, is owned by the German Catholic Society for the Holy Land (Deutsche Verein vom Heiligen Lande, under the head of the Archbishop of Cologne) and ministered by Benedictine monks of the Dormition Abbey in Jerusalem. The Church today is open to the public, while other parts of the compound serve as a Monastery with living quarters for personnel, a guest-house and camp for religious groups, gardens and shaded areas, and a secluded prayer spot on the shore of the lake recently established by the Benedictines and termed 'Dalmanutha' or 'Magadan Retreat' (after Mark 8:10, Matthew 15:39; Pixner 1992:84, 122) to which access is allowed to pilgrim groups when ordered in advance (Fig. 66).

This impressive Church is mainly a modern reconstruction (Fig. 68), planned by the German architects A. Goergen and F. Baumann and inaugurated in 1980, of the three-nave Byzantine 5th century C.E. basilica, incorporating the ancient ground plan and foundations as the basis for the modern structure. On display in the outer courtyard in front of the church are some ancient stone artifacts, including the crushing stones and pressing-basin of a Byzantine olive-press discovered nearby in the excavations of 1932. From here one enters into the atrium, whose inner open courtyard is adorned with a symbolic olive tree in its center and a small fish-pool fed by water spurting out of the mouths of seven bronze fish-sculptures (symbolizing the seven springs of Tabgha); a Corinthian-styled capital originating from the nearby Byzantine cathedral of the city of Hippos (Susita) lies above the pool. A souvenir shop adjoins the atrium on its northern flank. The entrance doors



into the Church itself are ornamented with bronze-sheet portrayals of biblical scenes.

The church interior was fashioned in 1980 with the aid of both in-situ (but relatively poorly preserved) structural remains and a meticulous evaluation of similar, contemporary churches: a towering, raised, wooden diagonal roof covers the church, while the capitals were reconstructed by duplicating a Hippos Cathedral exemplar, displayed today in the church atrium.

Fig. 66. Prayer on the shore of the Sea of Galilee at Tabgha

In two locations the foundations of the original 4th century church may still be discerned below current floor-level through panes of glass. Certainly the most impressive component of the church is the magnificent mosaic floor, mostly preserved intact in its original 5th century C.E. form and partly restored by Israel Museum experts. The centerpiece of the floor, adjacent to the altar and venerated rock within the main apse (Fig. 67), is the stirring depiction of the basket with loaves of bread and two fish that commemorates the miracle of the feeding of the multitudes; near it to the left of the altar a Greek inscription stating "To the Memory and the repose of the sponsor, the Holy Patriarch M[ar]t[yrios]" enables dating this floor to the late 5th century C.E. In the northern and southern transepts are mosaic carpets ornamented with Egyptian-motif floral and fauna elements depicting Nile-river scenery and landscape; today, after restoration, all the mosaic illustrations may be clearly observed and appreciated by visitors to the site. In the central nave are modern icon-depicted portraits of Mary and Jesus, as well as of Joseph the *Comes* and of Martyrios, the two saintly men to whom the construction of the church in the 4th and 5th centuries is attributed. All the above create a unique, serene and hallowed environment within the sacred space of this imposing edifice, erected here above the ancient remains of this centuries-old sacred Christian site.

Fig. 68. Reconstructed (1980) Church of the Multiplication – central nave

The ANSMI compound: (Associazione Nazionale Italiana Ernesto Schiapparelli = National Association for Aid to Italian missionaries): This is a relatively narrow strip of land not open to the public between The Benedictine area in the west and the Franciscan area in the east. This area is owned since the beginning of the 20th century by an Italian Missionary Association affiliated with the Catholic church, who also owns the stretch of land along the shore of the lake between Tabgha and Kefar Nahum. Within this compound, cared after by two Christian Nuns, is the largest of the springs of Tabgha – the Ein Tabgha or Ein Nur spring, upon which was built the large water-raising pool of Birket Ali Daher (= 'Ali Daher pool', referring to an 18th century Bedouin chief who renovated the ancient Byzantine pool) and from which water was gravitationally-hauled during the Byzantine period (and possibly even earlier) to water the fields of the valley of Ginnosar via an aqueduct whose well-preserved remains may still be seen today west of Tabgha.

The Church of the Primacy of St. Peter ('Mensa Christi'): The site is included in the Franciscan-owned eastern area of Tabgha. Along the path that leads down from the modern road towards the Church on the lake-shore are: to the right (west) of the path - a Byzantine stone-built water-raising installation (preserved to a height of 4 m', 14 m' in diameter; popularly called 'Tannur Ayub' [= Job's Oven, or Kiln), natural stone outcrops which were utilized in the Roman period as a quarry, and several modern open-air prayer-corners (Fig. 70)set up in recent years within a tranquil garden of grass, eucalyptus trees and flowers; to the left (east of the path) - are the private living quarters of the Monks and staff-caretakers of the site, among which are some ancient structures which include remains of several Ottoman-period watermills, a Crusader-period structure and stone and cement-strengthened

aqueducts that flow excess-water from a local salty spring westwards to the modern salt-water diversion canal. On the lake-shore itself is the Holy site of the Church of the Primacy (Fig. 69), today a small and modest church constructed in 1932 (and recently renovated) upon the earlier Byzantine and Crusader remains, the altar (Fig. 73) of which stands adjacent to the sanctified rock-outcrop (Fig. 71) identified in post-Byzantine pilgrim sources as the 'Mensa Christy' (= table of Christ, or 'Mensa Domini' = table of the lord). Adjacent to the church on its outer, southern side, are the sanctified 'steps' (originally part of the Roman rock-quarry in this area) mentioned by Egeria in the late 4th century C.E. as those on which Jesus stood (Wilkinson 1981: 196), while nearby, embedded in the ground, are six ancient

Fig. 71. The sanctified 'steps' of Jesus of The Church of the Primacy of St. Peter

heart-shaped stones (originally corner-pillar drums of an ancient public building) placed in a row in secondary use in memory of the 12 apostles. Some 50 meters east of the Church.

On the shoreline at elevation level -210 m', are the remains of the small ancient harbor of Tabgha (Fig. 72), one of the best examples among the ancient anchorages of the lake of Galilee. East of it is a gushing waterfall whose source is a modern artesian well above and behind the shoreline. Drilled in the 1960's by the water commissionership, it was unable to be sealed; as its water falls back into the lake and thus does not go to waste, it was left intact and is today an unofficial but popular recreation swimming and picnic site for Israeli families (access to the shore is from the east and not through the Mensa Christi compound's closed area). Above and to the north of the waterfall, slightly outside (east of) the eastern confines of the Mensa Christi compound, is another ancient water-raising 'tower' (4 m' high, 5.5 m' in diameter), popularly termed 'Hamam Ayub' (= Job's Bath).

Fig. 72. Tabgha Anchorage during low tide, view from the north

The Northern Slope

North and above the Tabgha-Kefar Nahum road begins the slope of the Mt. of Beatitudes. On the bottom steep part of the slope opposite the Ein Nur

spring ('Birket Ali Daher' [= Ali Daher pool] and adjacent to the road on its northern side, some 50 m' north-east of the Church of the Multiplication, are the remains of the Byzantine Chapel of the Beatitudes excavated by Fr. Bagatti in 1935, commemorating the site of the Sermon on the Mount as identified in the early Byzantine period. Although a decent view of the chapel's structural remains and sanctified cave (probably the one mentioned by Egeria in the late 4th century) is achieved from the road below, the site itself is hermetically closed to the public by a stone and wire fence, protecting it from vandalism and naturally-incurred damage.

Here we shall add that some scholars, headed by the Benedictine Fr. Bargil Pixner, prefer identifying the location of the Sermon on the Mount and the cave mentioned by Egeria – and possibly the cave where Jesus engaged in solitary prayer (Mark 6:46) - some 200 m' east of the Byzantine chapel, an area termed by Pixner as 'the Hillcrest of Eremos' (Pixner 1985: 197, 203; 1992: 37-39). Here, north of the road where the hill-slope is less steep, a good albeit narrow path leads up to a natural small 2 x 5 m' grotto locally termed 'Magharet Ayub' (= Job's cave), located opposite (north of) and above the eastern Franciscan section of Tabgha. This grotto, provided by B. Pixner with an inner wooden-bench for pilgrim-solitude and prayer, is visited today by many who come down on a pilgrim's stroll from the modern church of the Beatitudes. The natural limestone-terrace above the cave, extending to the west for some 20 meters, was identified by Pixner as the probable location of the delivering of the Sermon on the Mount. Some 20 meters west and above of the grotto, on a naturally-leveled eastern part of the terrace overlooking Tabgha below, a small gathering place with a square stone-altar, surrounded by three sculptured basalt boulders inscribed with New Testament passages, has been set up by Pixner for tranquil pilgrimage prayer. From here a path leads up for a 1 k"m walk to the modern Mt. of Beatitudes church; another leads down diagonally towards the south-west, reaching the road below the Byzantine chapel remains described above.

Fig. 74. View of Tabgha from the Mt. of Beatitude looking west.

The Tabgha Valley: In the western part of Tabgha is a flat plain that is cultivated today with olive and other fruit trees, and a banana plantation (Fig. 74). This lush part of Tabgha was most probably always cultivated in the past, and so the rural scene here is certainly

reminiscent of the ancient landscape. Along the shoreline of the plain several stone-anchors were discovered during the extreme drought of 1991, one of them a carved triangular exemplar. On the shoreline at the south-western corner of the valley, near the German-owned Pilgerhaus (= Pilgrim's house, itself an historical building erected in 1889), is an ancient anchorage whose remains are visible in low tide (Nun 1992:36-37; however, Nun mistakenly identifies this as the anchorage of New Testament period Gennesar). This anchorage, like the others along the lake's shoreline, is unexcavated and so is as yet undated; it may be one of the earliest, as it is in proximity to the ancient Bronze and Iron Age city of Kinneret that existed on the hill above the anchorage to its west.

History and Development of Heptapegon (Tabgha)

Outline of Archaeological Research and Development at Heptapegon (Tabgha)

Modern research and care for the site begin in the late 19th century, following the acquiring in the late 1880's of most of the lands in the environs of Tabgha by the German Catholic Society for the Holy Land (*Deutsche Verein vom Heiligen Lande*, in 1886*)* and by The Franciscan Custodians of the Holy Land (1889, some 5 years before their acquirement of Capernaum). Following is a concise historical survey of the main events pertaining to the archaeological research and modern development of the site since then (Schneider 1937; Loffreda 1968; Pixner 1985; Avi-Yonah 1993; Negev 1993):

- 1889-1890 - G. Schumacher conducts a survey of the site, indicating the location of the ruins of the Church of the Multiplication that were accidentally discovered while digging foundations for hut-construction by the German Catholic Society
- 1910 – The acquirement by the Italian Catholic society of a parcel of land including the main Ein Nur spring between the Franciscan and German Catholic estates
- 1911 – First excavation of the church of the Multiplication by P. Karge, including the re-discovery of the mosaic of the breadbasket and fish (already partly revealed at the end of the 19th century). The remains were covered over, for fear of Ottoman govt. negative reaction
- 1932-1936 – Full excavation by Frs. Mader and Schneider of the above church and the discovery and restoration of mosaic floors; 1933 – temporary church and protective shack erected over the ancient church remains.
- 1933 – On the lakeside upon ancient remains the Franciscans erect a new chapel commemorating the appearance of Jesus after resurrection (Church of the Primacy)
- 1935 – Excavation by B. Bagatti of the Byzantine Chapel commemorating the Sermon on the Mount.
- 1964 – Visit of Pope Paul VI to Tabgha.
- 1968-1969 – S. Loffreda and B. Bagatti conduct excavations in the environs of the Church of the Primacy.
- 1979-1980 – Trial soundings in the Church of the Multiplication by R. Rosenthal and M. Hershkovitz before restoration of mosaics.
- 1980-1982 – Erection and dedication of a new three-nave Monumental Basilical Church upon and incorporating the remains of the Byzantine Church of the Multiplication; restoration and display of the mosaic floors and other ancient remains

The History and Archaeology of Heptapegon (Tabgha)

History: The part of the Sea of Galilee offshore Tabgha has been known for ages as a superb winter fishing ground (exploited until today), due to its warm waters deriving from the warm springs of Tabgha that empty out into the lake (Nun 1989:12-14; 43-44). The springs onshore were also exploited for agriculture and hauled by aqueduct afar to the valley of

Gennesar to the south-west and possibly also to the area of Capernaum to the east. The valley of Tabgha itself was surely an important part of the rural agricultural periphery of the nearby Bronze and Iron Age Biblical city of *Kinneret* (Tel Oreima on the valley's south-western perimeter) and of Roman-Byzantine period Capernaum (3 k"m to the east), while its limestone-rock outcrops near the shore were also exploited in ancient times for quarrying (see below). Moreover, a Roman road to the Golan (a section of which was revealed while excavating the Church of the Multiplication; see below) passed by on the northern fringe of the valley, felicitating easy access to the area and connections with outer regions. Local tradition, seemingly kept among the Judeo-Christians of Capernaum, relates that it is here that Jesus met the fishermen who became his apostles, came to retire and seek solitude (Jesus's *Eremos*, secluded place), fed the multitude with five loaves and two fish, delivered the sermon on the mount (from a point overlooking the valley from the north) and appeared before the apostles after his resurrection (Pixner 1985; 1992: 36-37, 69-73). These traditions are recorded by the pious pilgrim Egeria in the late 4th century C.E., who mentions here the 'seven springs' by the 'grassy field' as the site of these traditions. In wake of the rise of Christian-Byzantine governmental control in that same century begins the physical development of the site with the erection of the first relatively modest churches of the multiplication (on the northern border of the valley), and of the primacy of St. Peter (on the shore of the lake). In the coming 5th and 6th centuries the Church of the Multiplication was built anew, enlarged and beautifully adorned, a monastery and a chapel commemorating the Sermon on the Mount ('Beatitudes') were erected on the rocky slope 50 m' north-east of the former, the Church of the Primacy was rebuilt and three water-raising towers were built above the main three springs of the valley, probably as part of an irrigation project utilizing the waters afar; this period was the apex of activity in Tabgha in ancient times, certainly a product of the commemoration of its traditional sites pertaining to the ministry of Jesus. The Arab conquest of the 7th century C.E. brought in its wake a certain sharp decline, and all the Churches were destroyed or fell into demise; however, excavations have shown that the church of the Primacy was built anew a number of times during the Early Islamic and Crusader periods (7th-13th centuries), visited now and then by pilgrims who mention the *Mensa Christi* or *Mensa Domini* on the site, referring to the venerated rock outcrop within the chapel (one 9th century pilgrim labels the site as 'the Church of the Twelve Thrones'). During the Crusader period there seems to have been a certain presence witnessed by the building of a tower north of the Church of the primacy. Since then and until the late 19th century Tabgha went through a long period of stagnation and inactivity – save for the utilization of its waters in the Ottoman period (16th-19th centuries) to operate flour-producing water-mills.

Archaeology: Pre-4th century C.E. remains in Tabgha include an extensive quarry and cup-marks along the shore in the area of the church of the primacy, dated to the Late-Roman period (a coin from 108/109 C.E. was found in one of the cuttings of the quarry; Loffreda 1968:240); a section of the stepped rock-cut quarry adjacent to the southern wall of the Church of the Primacy on the shoreline of the lake (Fig.71) is surely the site mentioned by the pious pilgrim Egeria ca. 390 C.E. as "some steps where the Lord stood" (Wilkinson 1981: 196)**,** referring to Jesus's appearance after resurrection. A small ancient anchorage on the shore east of the church that is exposed in low tide may also have existed already in new Testament times as is surmised by its discoverer (Nun 1992:38-39), similar to several other anchorages in other parts of the Sea of Galilee shores dated to the Roman period (e.g. at Magdala; Raban 1988: 322-323) . This overall picture fits well with the New Testament literary sources that refer to the area as an uninhabited area during the time of Jesus.

Byzantine period remains include the following excavated and investigated sites:

The Church of the Multiplying of the Loaves and Fish: (Schneider A. M. 1937; Pixner 1985; Avi-Yonah 1993; Negev 1993; Aviam 1997). The first 4th c. phase, one of the first churches erected in the Galilee (by Josephos the *Comes* in the times of the Emperor Constantine?; Pixner 1985: 198), is a small (9.5 X 15.5 m') single-roomed chapel oriented 28 degrees

southwards in relation to the later Byzantine Basilica (Fig. 75). This church is briefly described by Egeria ca. 390 C.E., who mentions that the stone on which the Lord placed the bread was turned into an altar and that pilgrims used to chip away pieces of it to bring them prosperity (although this passage may actually refer to the church of the primacy**;** Wilkinson 1981: 196).

During the second half of the 5th century a new and large (33 X 56 m') monumental three-naved church complex (including hospice rooms and an olive-oil production center) was constructed on the same site, using roughly dressed basalt local stones (in contrast to the Synagogue at Capernaum), oriented exactly to the east; the venerated rock-altar was removed from its original stone-setting and placed slightly to the east in line with the plan of the new church (where it is seen today). The church itself (19 x 25 m') was a T-shaped Basilica with transepts to the left and right of the altar, an exceptional plan in Byzantine Palestine.

The mosaic floors of the church are certainly the most admirable feature of the remains, being unusually imaginative and of high quality. First and foremost in importance is a depiction of a basket with loaves of bread marked with crosses, flanked by two fish, commemorating the miracle of the feeding of the multitudes. The two other principle mosaics are carpeted in the left and right transepts. The faunal and floral elements are depicted with exceptional naturalism: they include mostly birds (e.g. ducks, herons, geese, doves, swans, storks, flamingos – one in ruthless combat with a serpent - and cormorants) and plants, with scenes (some of them humorous) reminiscent of the Nile landscape in Egypt, including a drawing of a nilometer – used to measure the water level of the Nile. This also remarkably reminds one of Josephus Flavius' 1st century C.E. coincidental description of the Tabgha springs as an 'offshoot of the Nile' (Wars 3.10.8).

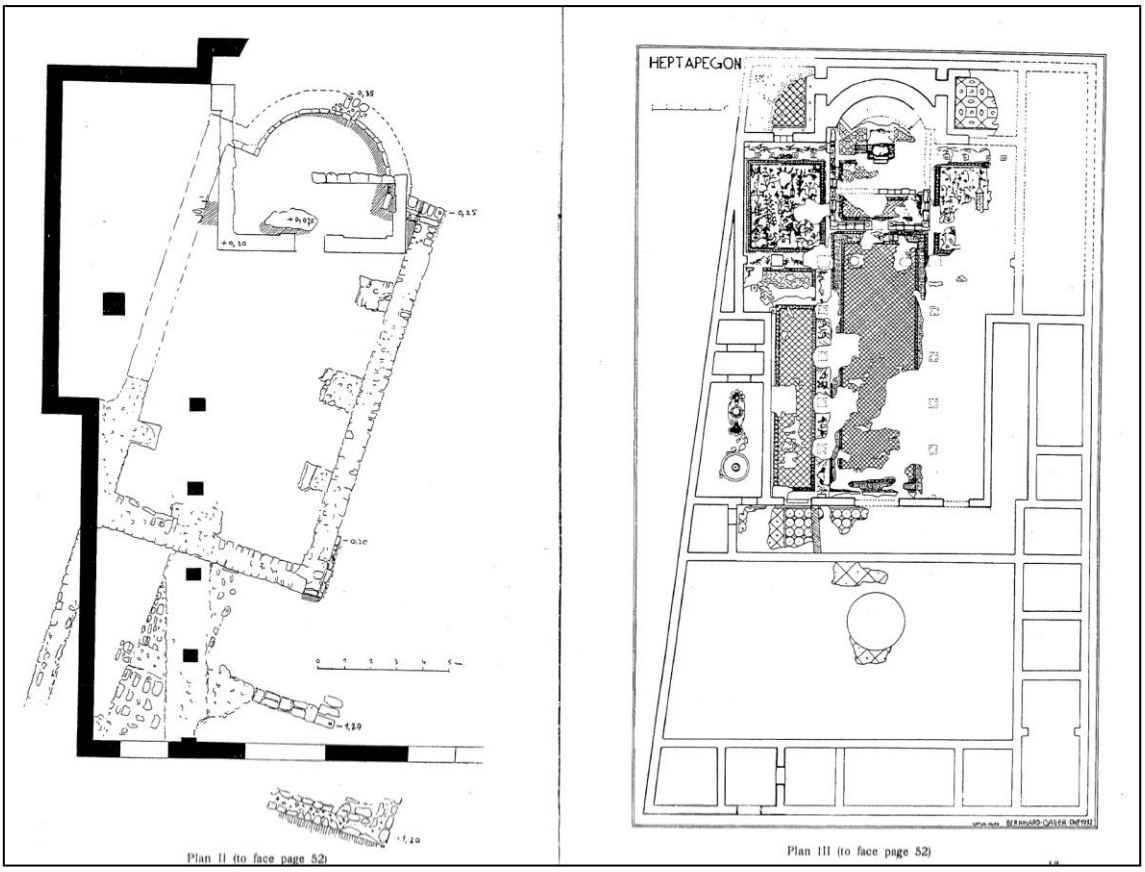


Fig. 75. Plans of the 4th (Plan 2) and 5th (Plan 3) centuries C.E. Churches of the Multiplication

Several fragmentary Greek inscriptions were uncovered, one of which is of chronological importance: "To the memory and the repose of the sponsor, the Holy Patriarch

M[ar]t[yrios]" – who was Patriarch of Jerusalem in the years 478 – 486 C.E. The church was destroyed sometime in the 7th C.E., as was the fate of many others in wake of the Persian and Arab conquests of Palestine in the first half of the 7th century.

The Chapel commemorating the Sermon on the Mount: (Bagatti 1937**;** Pixner 1985: 203). This site, on the rocky slope 50 m' north-east of the Church of the Multiplication, was sanctified in the 4th century C.E. and built in the commemoration of the Sermon on the Mount in the late 4th and 5th centuries C.E., possibly maintaining a tradition for the location of the narrative at this very spot. Excavations in 1935 revealed a small (4.5 X 10 m') one-naved chapel with an apse in the east, a narthex on its western side, a hewn room on its northern flank and annexed rooms continuing down the slope (part of a 10 x 22 m' former monastery); the chapel's walls were rock-hewn and plastered, on which remains of crosses and graffiti were noted. The floor was paved with mosaics, of which only a small part survived in the north-eastern area of the nave. Below the nave is a plastered, rock-hewn, 3.5 m' deep cistern. Egerias' account includes a passage that most scholars believe refers to this site: "near there on a mountain is the cave to which the Saviour climbed and spoke the Beatitudes" (Wilkinson 1981:200), where the 'cave' refers to the underground cistern below the nave.

The Church of the Primacy: (Loffreda 1968, 1969, 1970, 1978)**.** Excavations here in 1969-1970 have revealed a sequel of five small chapel-structures beginning from the late 4th century C.E., built in an area of an earlier quarry which includes a series of hewn 'steps' adjacent to the chapel on its southern side which most probably are the 'steps' mentioned by Egeria ca. 390 C.E. on which Jesus stood when reappearing before the apostles after his resurrection (Wilkinson 1981: 196). This chapel was repaired, in use and re-erected several times between the Byzantine and Mamluke (13th century C.E.) periods until its final demise, always accentuating a rock outcrop that was termed *Mensa Christi* or *Mensa Domini* by pilgrims. Sometime in antiquity six heart-shaped corner-pillar stones (which may be seen until today) originating from a former unknown public edifice were placed in a row alongside the southern side of the church; today they are dedicated to the 12 apostles.

Also dated to the Byzantine period are two stone tower-looking structures (but having no defensive purpose) which functioned in the past as water-raising installations located above two of the former local springs of salty and relatively hot water (popularly related to the Biblical Job, termed 'Tanur Ayub' and 'Hamam Ayub'), the 'Ali Daher' pool above the main spring of Ein Nur and the aqueduct whose remains are visible west of Tabgha which derives from that spring. A lone Crusader-period dated rectangular structure with relatively thick walls slightly north of the church of the Primacy is witness to some Crusader interest and activity at Tabgha, while during the Ottoman period Tabgha became a small flour-manufacturing center as is witnessed by the remains of seven canal-fed watermills that exploited the spring waters of the site.

Byzantine pilgrim sources as the 'Mensa Christy'.